PIA 3121:

Theory of International Relations

Semester A, 2026-2027

Course Outline and Schedule

Instructor: **Prof. Dan LYNCH** (dan.lynch@cityu.edu.hk)
TA: **Soon-to-Be Dr. SHEN Chenxi** (cxshen3-c@my.cityu.edu.hk)

REQUIRED BOOK

Viotti, Paul R. and Mark V. Kauppi. *International Relations Theory*. 6th edition. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2019.

RECOMMENDED BOOK

Reus-Smit, Christian and Duncan Snidal, eds. *The Oxford Handbook of International Relations*. Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press, 2008.

SCHEDULE OF READINGS and TOPICS

Note: We will announce the "milestone" due dates for components of the group paper project in class.

1 September (T): Tools of Analysis / Evolution of the International System

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on "Thinking About IR Theory," pp. 1-34.

8 September (T): Root Discourses: Realism

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on "Realism: The State and Balance of Power"

15 September (T): Liberalism and Neoliberalism vs. Realism and Neorealism I

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on "Liberalism: Interdependence and Global Governance"

22 September (T): Liberalism and Neoliberalism vs. Realism and Neorealism II

a. Robert Axelrod, "The Evolution of Cooperation," pp. 3-54; pp. 169-191.

29 September (T): Economic Structuralism / Globalization

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on "Economic Structuralism: Global Capitalism and Postcolonialism"

6 October (T): Constructivism

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on "Constructivist Understandings"

13 October (T): MIDTERM QUIZ (in-class)

20 October (T): Ontological Security Theory

a. Mitzen, Jennifer. 2006. "Ontological Security in World Politics: State Identity and the Security Dilemma." *European Journal of International Relations*, Vol. 12(3): 341-370.

b. Browning, Christopher S. and Pertti Joenniemi. 2017. “Ontological security, self-articulation and the securitization of identity.” *Cooperation and Conflict* 52(1): 31–47.

27 October (T): The English School

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on “The English School: International Society and Grotian Rationalism”

3 November (T): Democratization, Global Culture, and Revolution

a. Wucherpfennig, Julian and Franziska Deutsch. "Modernization and Democracy: Theories and Evidence Revisited." *Living Reviews in Democracy*, 2009, pp. 1-9.

b. Lynch, Daniel C. "Envisioning China's Political Future: Elite Responses to Democracy as a Global Constitutive Norm." *International Studies Quarterly* 51(3), September 2007, pp. 701-722.

10 November (T): Critical Theory / Gender in IR / Global Civil Society

a. Viotti and Kauppi, *International Relations Theory*, chapter on “Positivism, Critical Theory, and Postmodern Understandings;” and chapter on “Feminist Understandings in IR Theory”

17 November (T): Chaos and Complexity in IR / Existential Risks

a. Bostrom, Nick. "Existential Risk Prevention as Global Priority." *Global Policy* 4(1), February 2013, pp. 15-31.

24 November (T): FINAL QUIZ (in-class)

8 December (T): GROUP PAPER PROJECT DUE (by 11:59 pm)